- Your test suite runtime is less than your application startup time.
- Your test suite is slow, but you're willing to run just a small subset of your tests during much of your TDD development.
- Any port in a storm—it can't hurt to have a preloader, right?

I'll pause at this point to mention that I use Spring as part of my regular test practice. Pre–4.1 Rails, I used a similar tool called Zeus. So whatever else I say in the rest of this section, I do think that Spring is valuable in a lot of cases. Especially when I'm running a very small subset of failing tests over and over, it can be a significant win.

Spring is, however, one of those tools that best helps you when you're already helping yourself. If your test suite takes 20 minutes to run, you're already sunk and the 15 extra seconds to load Rails isn't going to help much.

Spring can also hide problems in a test suite by letting you run individual pieces of the suite much faster; it can reduce the pressure you might feel to speed up each individual test file. There's a Spring "uncanny valley": if an individual file takes 30 seconds, that's both fast enough for Spring to feel like a win and slow enough for it to be a serious drain on the entire project suite as you continue to add up 30-second files. You don't want to be there. It'll feel like your suite isn't getting any worse, but trust me—it is.

That said, if you're already stuck in a bad situation because you inherited it (or for whatever reason), Spring can be great and can allow you to have fast TDD feedback on the new stuff you're building without being tied to the poor decisions of the past. Just don't keep making the same poor decisions.

Running Tests Automatically with Guard

Another way to get test feedback quickly is to allow the tests to run automatically when your code changes. In Ruby, the Guard gem allows you to trigger arbitrary events when files change.[2] It's a powerful system, and running tests is only a fraction of what it can do. You're just going to manage basic setup here; full documentation is available online. Mac users should check out the Mac-specific wiki page to make sure Guard receives file events correctly.[3]

Guard is a generic system for triggering events, and it has separate libraries that make it easy to trigger specific kinds of events, such as starting a test.

2. http://guardgem.org
3. https://github.com/guard/guard/wiki/Add-Readline-support-to-Ruby-on-Mac-OS-X